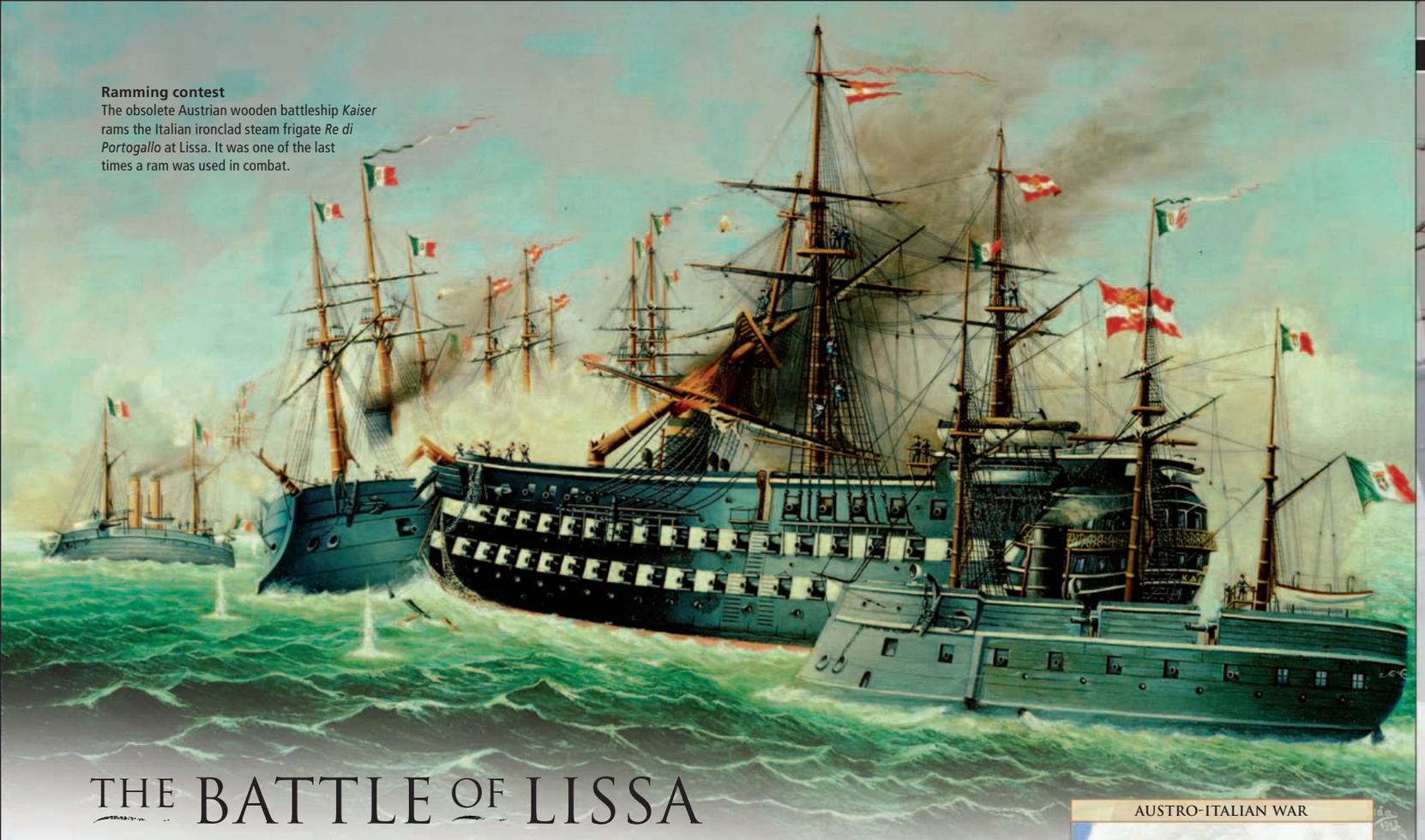


Ramming contest
The obsolete Austrian wooden battleship *Kaiser* rams the Italian ironclad steam frigate *Re di Portogallo* at Lissa. It was one of the last times a ram was used in combat.

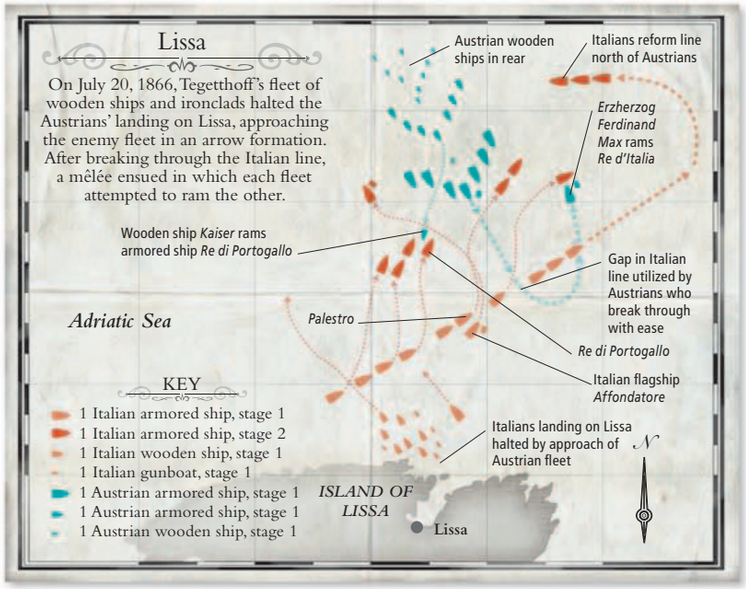
THE BATTLE OF LISSA

In 1866 Italy went to war with Austria in alliance with Prussia. From an Italian point of view the main aim of the war was to free Venice from Austrian rule. On July 20 an Italian fleet under Count Carlo di Persano was preparing to land troops on the island of Lissa, then part of the Austrian Empire. An Austrian fleet under Wilhelm von Tegetthoff was sent to prevent the landings.

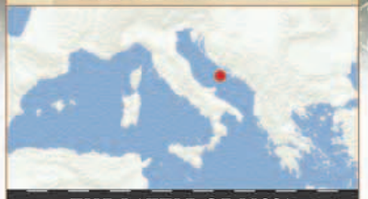
Occurring at a transitional time in naval technology, the battle was fought by a mix of ironclads and wooden ships, all with both steam propulsion and sails, and most with guns in broadside.

Tegetthoff had the weaker force, but he hoped to compensate by breaking the battle into a mêlée in which his ships might win individual duels. He arranged his fleet in a V formation, advancing toward the Italians with the ironclads in the van. Due to a confusion of orders, the Italians ended up in a ragged line with ironclads and wooden ships interspersed and a large gap between the van and the center. Toward this gap Tegetthoff gratefully plunged, braving the Italian broadsides that decapitated one of his captains but otherwise caused only limited damage.

Once at close quarters the Austrians fought with outstanding skill. Tegetthof's ship *Erzherzog Ferdinand Max* rammed two ironclads, *Re d'Italia* (twice) and *Palestro*, as well as battering them with close-range gunfire. *Re d'Italia* was gouged open below the waterline by Tegethoff's second ramming attack and sank in two minutes. *Palestro* eventually exploded, killing most of its crew who had gallantly refused a chance to abandon ship. Meanwhile, the large Austrian wooden battleship *Kaiser*, under Captain Anton von Petz, engaged no less than four ironclads in the Italian rear. Von Petz lost his stem and bowsprit ramming the *Re di Portogallo* and had his smokestack and mainmast shot off, but successfully withdrew his crippled ship from the battle. For his victory, Tegetthoff justly became an Austrian national hero.



AUSTRO-ITALIAN WAR



THE BATTLE OF LISSA

Date	July 20, 1866
Location	Adriatic, off Croatia
Result	Austrian victory

COMBATANTS

ITALY	AUSTRIA

COMMANDERS

Carlo di Persano	Wilhelm von Tegetthoff

FORCES

Ships: 12 ironclads, 10 wooden steamships	**Ships:** 7 ironclads, 7 wooden steamships

LOSSES

Men: 660 casualties **Ships:** 2 ironclads	**Men:** 176 casualties **Ships:** none



1827–1871

WILHELM VON TEGETTHOFF

COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF OF THE AUSTRIAN NAVY

Commissioned as an officer in the Austrian navy in 1849, Tegetthoff had no chance to show his talents as a naval commander in combat until the war with Denmark in 1864. His spirited engagement of a Danish squadron at Heligoland was hailed in Austria as an outstanding naval feat and he was raised from captain to rear admiral. As commander-in-chief of the Austrian navy in 1866, his bold attack upon the Italian fleet at Lissa contrasted vividly with the poor performance of Austrian land forces, which were crushed by Prussians.